

The Sustainable Development Goals Report

2024



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The Sustainable Development Goals Report **2024**

Foreword

The Sustainable Development Goals Report 2024 makes for sobering reading.

It finds that only 17 per cent of the SDG targets are on track, nearly half are showing minimal or moderate progress, and progress on over one third has stalled or even regressed.

The scarring effects of the COVID-19 pandemic, escalating conflicts, geopolitical tensions, and growing climate chaos are hitting SDG progress hard.

Furthermore, systemic deficiencies and inequities in the global economic and financial system leave developing countries to tackle enormous and growing challenges with only a fraction of the international support they need and deserve.

Inequalities keep growing. The climate crisis continues to escalate. Biodiversity loss is accelerating. Progress towards gender equality remains disappointing. And conflicts in Ukraine, Gaza, Sudan and beyond have left an unprecedented 120 million forcibly displaced people worldwide.

This situation is not going to improve on its own: developing countries, as a whole, face the worst medium-term economic outlook in a generation.

Against this backdrop, the steadfast unity of governments behind the 2030 Agenda, as demonstrated at the SDG Summit in September 2023, offers a glimmer of hope.

Their commitment to rescue the SDGs and to deliver an SDG Stimulus has generated fresh impetus behind the Goals.

This report also highlights that despite deeply worrying trends, progress is being made – with reductions in child mortality, HIV infections, and the cost of remittances and improvements in access to water, sanitation, energy, and mobile broadband.

To turn these green shoots into accelerated and transformative progress, bolder actions are required:

First, we need peace.

We must resolve ongoing armed conflicts through dialogue and diplomacy, and prevent future conflicts by upholding the principles and values of the Charter of the United Nations.

Second, we need solidarity.

Developing countries urgently require more financial resources and fiscal space. We must reform the outdated, dysfunctional and unfair international financial architecture to facilitate far greater investment in the SDGs.

Third, we need a surge in implementation.

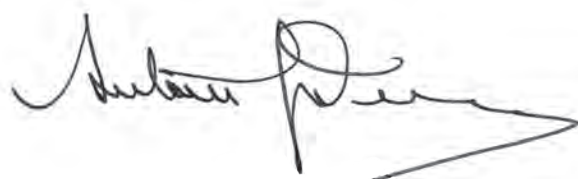
Massive investment and more effective partnerships are needed to drive critical transitions across food, energy, digital connectivity and more, unlocking progress right across the Goals.

And underpinning all our efforts must be a more concerted effort to dismantle gender barriers and empower all women and girls – because we cannot expect to achieve the Goals without gender equality.

This report highlights the urgent need for stronger and more effective international cooperation to maximize progress starting now.

This year's Summit of the Future provides a vital opportunity, paving the way for further breakthroughs at the Financing for Development conference and World Social Summit in 2025.

With more than six years left, we must not let up on our 2030 promise to end poverty, protect the planet and leave no one behind.



António Guterres
Secretary-General of the United Nations

Introduction

A promise in peril

Last September, Heads of State and Government gathered in New York for the SDG Summit to review progress towards the Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) and deliberate on areas requiring acceleration. Crucially, they reaffirmed their commitment to the SDGs, agreeing on the need for urgent, ambitious and transformative efforts to achieve the Goals in full by 2030. In the political declaration adopted by the General Assembly, Member States recognized that “the achievement of the SDGs is in peril” and stated their determination “to make all efforts to implement the 2030 Agenda and achieve the Sustainable Development Goals by the target year of 2030”.

Nearly a year later, intensifying, interconnected challenges continue to endanger the realization of the SDGs by the 2030 deadline. *The Sustainable Development Goals Report 2024* reveals that progress has ground to a halt or been reversed across multiple fronts, despite reaffirmed pledges. The lingering impacts of COVID-19, compounded by conflicts, climate shocks and economic turmoil, have aggravated existing inequalities. An additional 23 million people were pushed into extreme poverty and over 100 million more suffered from hunger in 2022 compared to 2019. While some health targets improved, overall global health progress has decelerated alarmingly since 2015. The COVID-19 pandemic has undone nearly 10 years of progress on life expectancy. Education, the bedrock of sustainable development, remains gravely threatened as many countries see declines in student math and reading skills, jeopardizing core competencies that will determine future prosperity.

A world in great upheaval

Around the world, wars are upending millions of lives, driving the highest number of refugees (37.4 million) and forcibly displaced people (nearly 120 million) ever recorded. Civilian casualties in armed conflicts rose by 72 per cent between 2022 and 2023, the highest spike since the adoption of the 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development in 2015. In 2023, 4 in 10 civilians killed in conflicts were women and 3 in 10 were children.

The cumulative impact of multiple environmental crises is threatening the foundations of planetary ecosystems. In 2023, the world experienced the warmest year on record. For the first time, global temperatures were dangerously close to the 1.5°C lower limit of the Paris Agreement. Global greenhouse gas emissions and atmospheric concentrations of carbon dioxide reached new records yet again in 2022, with no signs of slowing in 2023.

Developing and vulnerable countries face vast development challenges. Per capita growth in gross domestic product (GDP) in half the world's most vulnerable countries is now slower than in advanced economies for the first time this century. This trajectory threatens to reverse a long-term trend towards more income equality among countries. Furthermore, after a decade of rapid debt accumulation, the external debt stock in low- and middle-income countries remains at unprecedentedly high levels. The SDG investment gap in developing countries now stands at \$4 trillion per year. These problems are exacerbated by the fact that developing countries are inadequately represented in global economic decision-making, with their voting share falling far short of their membership in many international financial institutions.

A moment of choice and consequence

Time and again, humanity has demonstrated that when we work together and apply our collective mind, we can forge solutions to seemingly intractable problems. This report highlights some encouraging advancements. Increased access to life-saving treatment has averted 20.8 million AIDS-related deaths in the past three decades. In most regions of the world, girls have achieved parity and even pulled ahead of boys in completing schooling at all levels. Two thirds of the world's population – 5.4 billion people – now have access to the Internet, just as work and employment opportunities are being profoundly transformed by technological innovations such as artificial intelligence (AI).

The world must now confront head on the multiple crises threatening sustainable development, marshalling the determination, ingenuity and resources that such high stakes demand. To get the SDGs back on track, one foremost priority for the global community is to rally all stakeholders to end the conflicts causing unimaginable suffering and misery globally. Sustainable development is simply not possible without peace.

Additionally, wealthy economies need to unlock greater financing for vulnerable countries, and developing countries must gain a more equitable role in global economic governance and the international financial system.

In all countries, doubling down to pursue a just climate transition is crucial to addressing the triple planetary crisis of climate change, air pollution and biodiversity loss while reorienting economies towards more sustainable growth. Achieving dignity for all people of all ages requires renewed commitments to gender equality as well as significantly increased investments in health, education and social protection.

The time for words has passed. The political declaration of the SDG Summit must be translated into actions. It is still possible to create a better, more sustainable and more inclusive world for all by 2030. But the clock is running out. We must act now, and act boldly.



Li Junhua

Under-Secretary-General for Economic and Social Affairs

Unlocking the power of data for sustainable development

Accurate, timely and disaggregated data are vital for measuring progress towards the 17 Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) and 169 associated targets. Data help identify challenges, formulate solutions, monitor implementation and make needed course corrections. Without high-quality data providing an evidence base, it will be impossible to truly understand where we are succeeding and falling short on the SDGs. *The Sustainable*

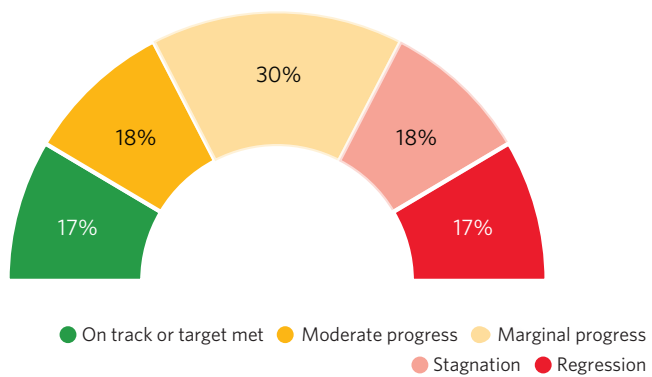
Development Goals Report 2024 provides a comprehensive overview of the world's progress nine years into the journey to 2030. Using the latest available data, the report highlights both successes and challenges as the international community strives to fully realize the ambitions and principles of the 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development.

I. The current status of the SDGs: severely off track

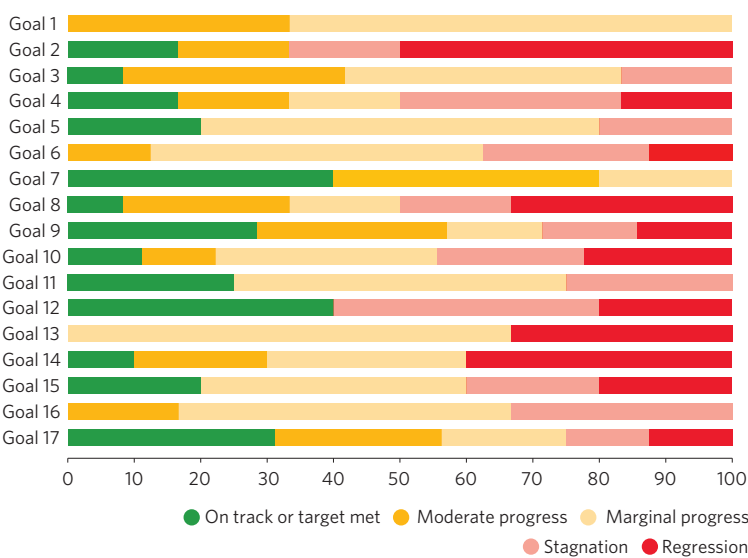
The progress assessment carried out in 2024 reveals that the world is severely off track to realize the 2030 Agenda. Of the 169 targets, 135 can be assessed using available global trend data from the 2015 baseline to the most recent year, along with custodian agency analyses; 34 targets lack sufficient trend data or additional analysis. Among the assessable targets, only 17 per cent display progress sufficient for achievement by 2030. Nearly half

(48 per cent) exhibit moderate to severe deviations from the desired trajectory, with 30 per cent showing marginal progress and 18 per cent moderate progress. Alarming, 18 per cent indicate stagnation and 17 per cent regression below the 2015 baseline levels.¹ This comprehensive assessment underscores the urgent need for intensified efforts to put the SDGs on course. Detailed analysis by target can be found at the end of this report.

Overall progress across targets based on 2015–2024 global aggregate data



Progress assessment for the 17 Goals based on assessed targets, by Goal (percentage)

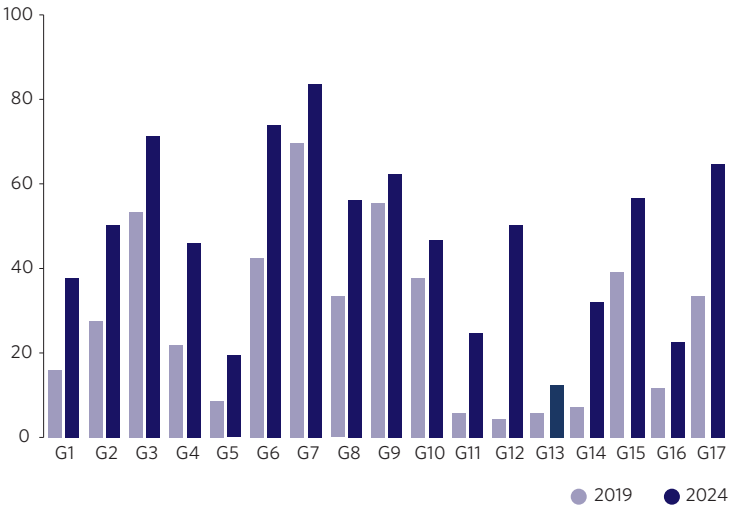


II. Despite commendable increases in data to monitor the SDGs, critical gaps persist

SDG progress assessment is affected by ongoing challenges in the availability and timeliness of data to monitor all 17 Goals. Overall, commendable progress has been made in improving internationally comparable data for SDG monitoring. In 2016, when the global indicator framework for the Goals and associated targets was initially adopted, only about one third of indicators had good data coverage (that is, data were available for more than 50 per cent of countries), and 39 per cent of the indicators lacked internationally established methodologies or standards. Today, 68 per cent of indicators have good data coverage. Since 2020, all 231 indicators have had well-established and internationally agreed methodologies. Good trend data are available for 51 per cent of the indicators (at least two data points since 2015) in more than half of all countries.

The variance in country data coverage plays out differently across the Goals, with major shortfalls in priority development areas, such as gender equality (Goal 5), climate action (Goal 13), and peace, justice and strong institutions (Goal 16). Moreover, data timeliness remains a challenge. Approximately one third of indicators lack data for the past three years, hampering the ability of policymakers to make timely informed decisions and course corrections.

Proportion of countries or areas with trend data (at least two data points since 2015), comparing 2019 and 2024 databases, by Goal (percentage)



¹ Due to new data and revised methodologies, this year's progress assessment is not comparable to those of previous years.

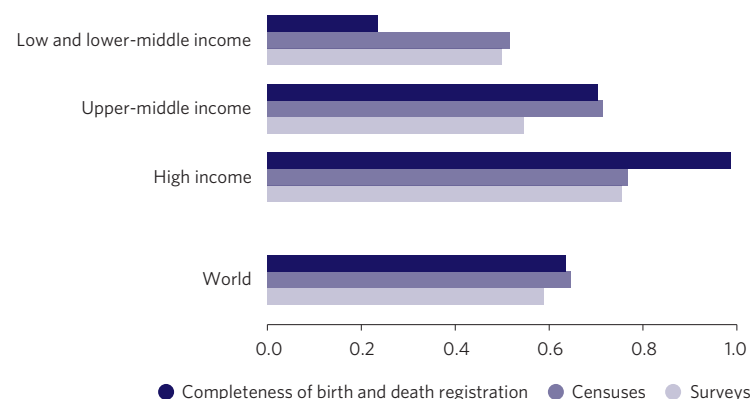
III. How to harness the power of data

Robust data build on a strong statistical foundation, innovation and integration

A strong statistical foundation draws on both traditional and innovative data sources. Traditional data sources include censuses, surveys and administrative data. Population censuses provide crucial data for national and subnational planning and also serve as denominators for numerous SDG indicators. Household surveys contribute data for about one third of SDG indicators, according to the Inter-Secretariat Working Group on Household Surveys. Birth and death registrations are vital for accurate population data and ensure individuals' legal rights, providing essential documentation for accessing health care, education and inheritances.

Many countries still face challenges, however, in building a robust statistical foundation with data from these three traditional sources. In 2022, overall performance on them across countries averaged around 0.6 (out of 1).

Statistical performance of countries on birth and death registration, censuses and surveys, by income level, 2022 (score 0–1)



Notable disparities existed across countries. High-income countries achieved nearly a full score for birth and death registration; upper-middle-income countries had an average score of 0.7; low- and lower-middle-income countries scored only 0.2. Disparities in censuses and surveys based on income level also persist, with scores from 0.5 to 0.8, although differences were less pronounced.

Data demand for SDG monitoring has spurred innovation and the integration of different data sources. For instance, Azerbaijan uses remote sensing to monitor the coverage of important sites for mountain biodiversity (SDG indicator 15.4.1). Colombia and Malaysia have integrated geospatial and population data to estimate the proportion of the rural population living within 2 kilometres of an all-season road (SDG indicator 9.1.1). Bangladesh has employed geospatial and survey data to generate local poverty estimates to inform government policies. Ghana and the United Kingdom have tapped into citizen science data to monitor marine litter (SDG indicator 14.1.1). Kyrgyzstan's statistical office collaborates with a network of civil society organizations to explore how citizen data can support the Voluntary National Review. Both the Netherlands and Uruguay monitor air pollution with national networks of sensors (SDG indicator 11.6.2).

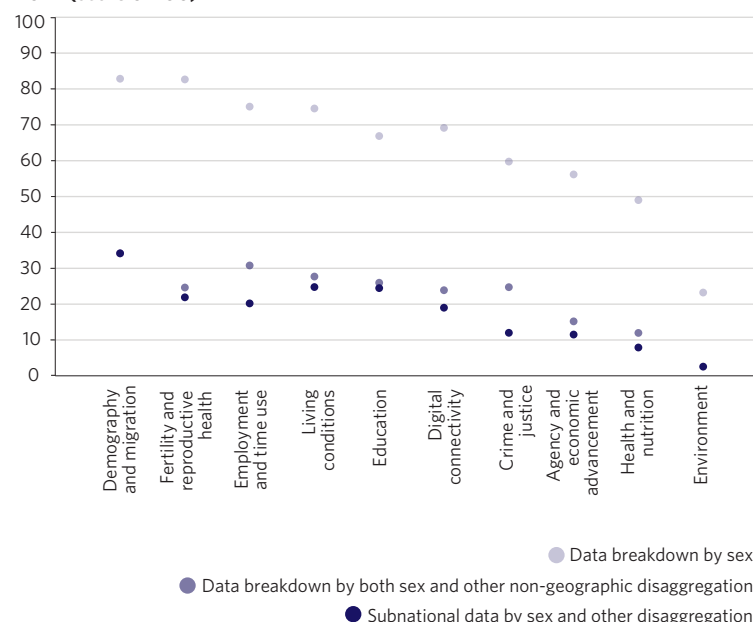
Countries worldwide are recognizing the need to invest in national statistical systems to produce high-quality, timely data for SDG monitoring. This involves not only financial resources but also requires building capacity, modernizing infrastructure and adopting international statistical standards. As countries continue to strengthen statistical foundations, embracing innovation and integrating diverse data sources and methodologies will be critical in overcoming challenges such as declining response rates as well as in fostering collaborative partnerships.

Engaging citizens in data production is essential to leave no one behind

The overarching principle of the 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development is to leave no one behind. A comprehensive review by the Gender Data Compass, however, revealed significant gaps in disaggregated data for key social, economic and environmental indicators disseminated online by national statistical offices (NSOs). In 2023, the availability score for sex-disaggregated data ranged from 23 to 83 out of 100. Sex-disaggregated data were most available for indicators on demographics, migration, fertility and reproductive health (with a score of 83) and least available for environmental indicators (23).

Further disaggregation by additional characteristics resulted in a significant decrease in data availability. For example, the availability score for demographic and migration indicators dropped to 34 when including disaggregation by sex and other non-geographic characteristics. Subnational data availability was notably low, with average scores ranging from 3 to 34. Interestingly, high-income countries generally exhibited lower overall disaggregated data availability compared to low- and middle-income countries.

Data availability score by sex and other characteristics and type of indicator, 2022 (score 0–100)



Ensuring that no one is left behind calls for more than just data disaggregation. Uncovering the intersectional disadvantages faced by the most marginalized groups demands additional efforts. For example, a side event on citizen data at the fifty-fifth session of the United Nations Statistical Commission showed that indigenous women and girls with disabilities in Bolivia faced significant challenges in accessing reproductive health information and care. Addressing these challenges and formulating relevant policies to overcome them is possible only when citizen data are collected with the active involvement and support of communities with firsthand knowledge of their own needs.

Data openness has improved; use and impact need more work

The increased openness, accessibility and effective use of data have been crucial to better data impact. Since the adoption of the 2030 Agenda, countries have made significant progress in opening up official statistics for public use. According to Open Data Inventory, the average score on data openness for around 180 countries and areas increased from 44 in 2017 to 55 in 2022. The openness level was greater in high-income countries, with a score of 67 in 2022, compared to only 42 for low- or lower-middle-income countries. This score represents official statistics that are machine-readable, non-proprietary, have an open data licence or open data terms of use, include available metadata and offer accessible download options.

Data openness does not always translate into effective use and impact, however. Monitoring these dimensions has been challenging. The Statistical Performance Indicators framework covers data use by national legislatures and executive branches, civil society, academia and international organizations, but only data use by international organizations is available. More efforts are needed to strengthen data use and impact, and measure and document results.

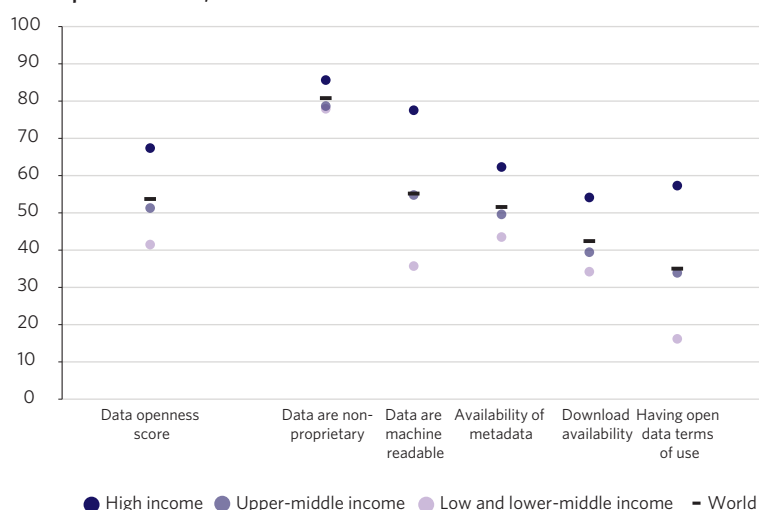
The role of national statistical offices as data stewards is evolving but challenges in data governance remain

Successful SDG monitoring requires NSOs to play a strong stewardship role within the national data ecosystem. According to a 2023 survey on data stewardship, nearly all NSOs reported having the mandate to coordinate the production and integration of official statistics across the national statistical system. Perceptions of successful data stewardship, however, varied. While almost 90 per cent of NSOs agreed that increased data sharing and reuse within the national statistical system were top priorities, they did not universally recognize active engagement with census and survey respondents, media interaction and improved data literacy as indicators of effective stewardship.

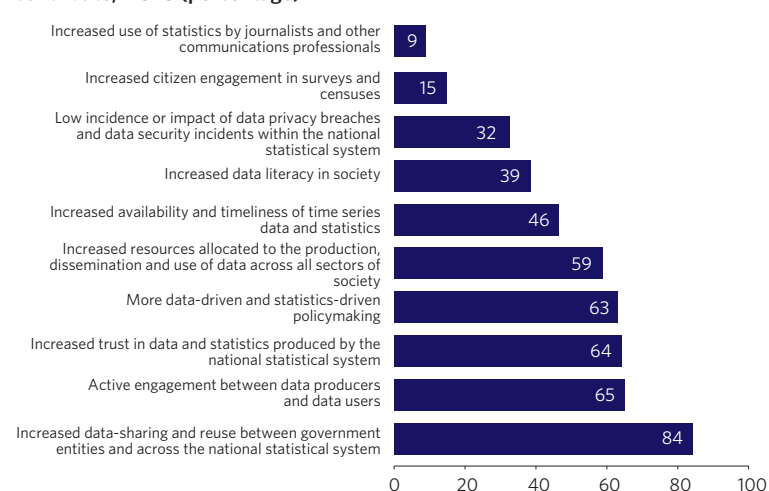
Ensuring data privacy and security is crucial in today's world, with data produced by both State entities and non-State actors, such as the private sector and civil society organizations. Surprisingly, only 30 per cent of NSOs considered this aspect important in their data stewardship role. This finding is consistent with responses to another survey question on which entities are responsible for different aspects of official statistics. While 80 per cent of NSOs either led or co-led technical and statistical standard-setting, only 50 per cent played a role in data security. This underscores the urgent need to establish national data governance systems that go beyond the current scope of NSO activities.

Involving citizens in data production signifies a shift towards a more collaborative and participatory model of governance, marking a new chapter in the social contract between State institutions and citizens. This refreshed dynamic embodies principles of transparency, participation and shared responsibility, reflecting an evolving relationship where citizens are not just subjects of governance but active participants in it. The newly proposed Copenhagen Framework on Citizen Data by the Collaborative on Citizen Data supports such engagement.

Data openness score, 2022



Proportion of NSOs agreeing on areas where successful data stewardship could contribute, 2023 (percentage)



Strengthening partnerships is key to more inclusive data

Building partnerships with diverse stakeholders makes SDG monitoring more inclusive and incorporates different perspectives and needs. According to a 2022 survey on the implementation of the Cape Town Global Action Plan for Sustainable Development Data, 81 per cent of NSOs had institutional arrangements with the public sector, followed by international organizations at 66 per cent, academia at 56 per cent and the private sector at 45 per cent. Partnerships between NSOs and civil society organizations stood at 37 per cent. A similar trend was observed in the production of gender statistics, with government ministries being the most common partners. Around 90 per cent of NSOs had established regular or ad hoc collaborations with other government entities, compared to only 37 per cent with civil society organizations.

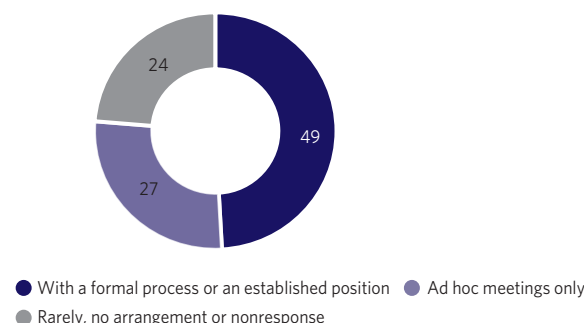
As more countries recognize the importance of adopting a “whole-of-society” approach to achieve the ambitious goals of the 2030 Agenda, increased efforts are being made to acknowledge the contributions of civil society. For example, with support from the Collaborative on Citizen Data and the United Nations country team, the Bangladesh Bureau of Statistics is establishing a formal partnership with civil society organizations to produce and use citizen data. This initiative represents a significant step for the country in recognizing data generated by non-state institutions.

Similar partnerships have flourished globally. At the SDG Summit in September 2023, the High Impact Initiative on the Power of Data was launched. It aims to deliver data needed to achieve the SDGs by mobilizing political support and investments in national data systems, fostering unified national data strategies, and strengthening partnerships, collaboration and

coordination. The expanding initiative currently comprises 15 countries across Africa, Asia and Latin America and Caribbean. More countries and partners are encouraged to join this important effort to ensure that every government has data to monitor and drive SDG progress.

Partnering with local governments enables NSOs to gather more accurate, comprehensive and context-specific data, enhancing the overall effectiveness of SDG monitoring and the responsiveness of development efforts to local priorities. According to the 2023 data stewardship survey, 49 per cent of NSOs had established a formal process or dedicated position for collaborating with local officials; 27 per cent had organized ad hoc meetings for such collaboration; 24 per cent either had rare or no arrangements or did not respond to this question on the survey.

Mechanisms to collaborate with municipal/city government data stewards, 2023 (percentage)



Coordinated efforts can close funding gaps and boost national data and statistical capacity

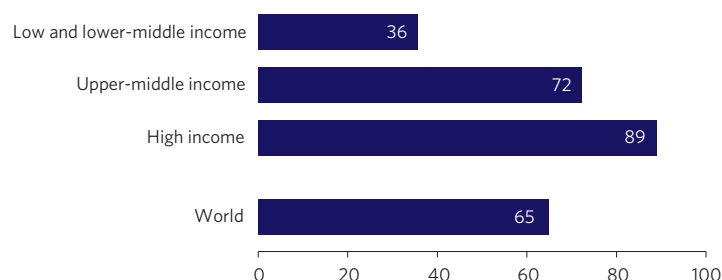
In 2023, only 65 per cent of countries had fully funded and implemented national statistical plans. The funding gap is more pronounced in low- and lower-middle-income countries, where only 35 per cent have sufficient funding, compared to only 11 per cent of high-income countries. Forty-five countries or areas received funding from donors; half were low- and lower-middle-income countries.

In the Hangzhou declaration on accelerating progress on the Cape Town Global Action Plan for Sustainable Development Data, countries agreed on “an urgent and sustained increase in the level and scale of investments in data and statistics from domestic and international actors, from the public, private and philanthropic sectors, to strengthen statistical capacity in low-income countries and fragile states, close data gaps for vulnerable groups and enhance country resilience in the current context of economic crisis, conflict, climate change and increased food insecurity.”

While acknowledging the contribution of development partners in building national data and statistical capacity, a holistic approach to such support is crucial to prevent silos and duplicated efforts. Effective coordination and proper funding allocations between development partners and national

entities are imperative to systematically address data and capacity gaps. Mechanisms such as the Statistical Training Needs Assessment Tool, developed by the Global Network of Institutions for Statistical Training, can aid in systematically assessing national statistical capacities to guide funding allocations. Colombia and Ghana have used the tool to develop plans that help prioritize capacity-building needs.

Proportion of countries with a national statistical plan that is fully funded and under implementation, 2023 (percentage)





No poverty

- The COVID-19 pandemic and subsequent shocks from 2020 to 2022 have hampered global efforts to eradicate extreme poverty. The global extreme poverty rate increased in 2020 for the first time in decades, setting back progress by three years. Since then, recovery has been uneven, with low-income countries lagging behind. By 2030, 590 million people may still live in extreme poverty if current trends persist. Without a substantial acceleration in poverty reduction, fewer than 3 in 10 countries are expected to halve national poverty by 2030.
- Despite increasing efforts and commitments to expand social protection programmes, significant coverage gaps left 1.4 billion children uncovered in 2023.
- Climate change is hindering poverty reduction, and disasters result in millions of households becoming poor or remaining trapped in poverty.



Traders transport charcoal to the market in Madagascar, among the countries with the world's highest poverty rates.

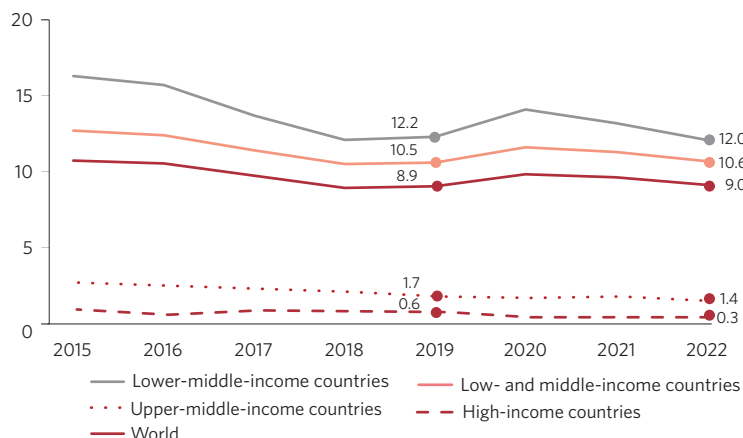
- Ending poverty requires a wide-ranging approach that combines comprehensive social protection systems, inclusive economic policies, investments in human capital, measures to address inequality and climate resilience, and international cooperation and partnership.

Extreme poverty rates have returned to pre-pandemic levels except in low-income countries

The COVID-19 pandemic caused extreme poverty to rise in 2020 for the first time in decades, reversing global progress by three years. The share of the world's population living in extreme poverty rose from 8.9 per cent in 2019 to 9.7 per cent in 2020, driven by increases in low- and lower-middle-income countries. In contrast, extreme poverty continue to decline in upper-middle- and high-income countries, attributed to swift fiscal support for vulnerable groups. By 2022, extreme poverty had returned to pre-pandemic levels in most countries, except low-income ones. In 2022, 712 million people (or 9 per cent of the world's population) lived in extreme poverty, an increase of 23 million people over 2019. Projections suggest that by 2030, 590 million people, or 6.9 per cent of the global population, may remain in extreme poverty if current trends persist.

In the 75 most vulnerable countries, which qualify for concessional lending from the World Bank's International Development Association, one in four people live on less than \$2.15 a day – more than eight times the extreme poverty rate in the rest of the world. One in three of these countries are now poorer on average than before the pandemic.

Proportion of the population living below \$2.15/day, by country income level, 2015–2022 (percentage)



Note: The lack of recent survey data limits the reporting of extreme poverty estimates exclusively for low-income countries.

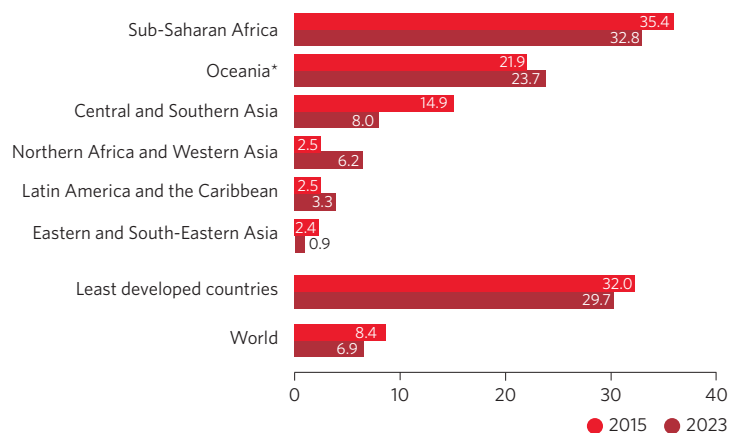
Working poverty has declined but still afflicts 241 million workers

The global working poverty rate slightly increased to 7.7 per cent in 2020 before declining to 6.9 per cent in 2023. This indicates a consistent downward trend in working poverty worldwide since 2015. Despite progress, nearly 241 million workers globally still lived in extreme poverty in 2023. Little positive change is expected in 2024.

There are wide regional disparities amid the overall positive global trend. Despite a falling working poverty rate, more than half of workers living in extreme poverty were still in sub-Saharan Africa (145 million). Central and Southern Asia notably reduced working poverty by 6.9 percentage points between 2015 and 2023. Conversely, Northern Africa and Western Asia saw an increase in the rate from 2.5 per cent in 2015 to 6.2 per cent in 2023.

Working poverty disproportionately affects some groups. Globally, youth are twice as likely as adults to be in working poverty. Women typically experience higher working poverty rates than men, with the most pronounced gender gap observed in the least developed countries (LDCs).

Proportion of the employed population living below \$2.15/day, 2015 and 2023 (percentage)



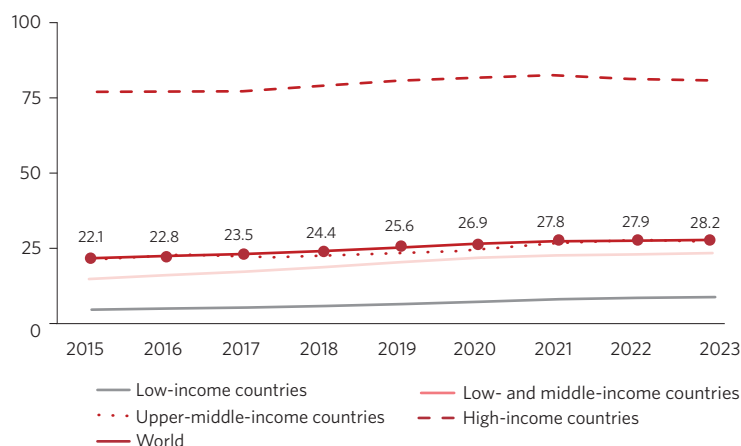
* Excluding Australia and New Zealand.

Despite improvement, 7 in 10 children worldwide still lack social protection coverage

In 2023, only 28.2 per cent of children aged 0 to 15 globally received child cash benefits, up from 22.1 per cent in 2015. This left 1.4 billion children without social protection coverage. Significant regional variations were evident, and despite a near doubling of coverage from 4.5 per cent in 2015 to 8.7 per cent in 2023, low-income countries were still far from universal coverage. During the same period, lower-middle-income and upper-middle-income countries raised coverage from 15.0 to 23.5 per cent and from 21.8 to 27.8 per cent, respectively. High-income countries maintained a continued progression towards universal coverage, with rates rising from 76.8 to 80.5 per cent.

Achieving universal coverage will require closing a major financing gap. To guarantee at least basic social security for all children, upper- and lower-middle-income countries would need to invest an additional \$98.1 billion and \$88.8 billion, respectively. Low-income countries would require an additional \$59.6 billion.

Proportion of children covered by social protection cash benefits, by country income level, 2015-2023 (percentage)

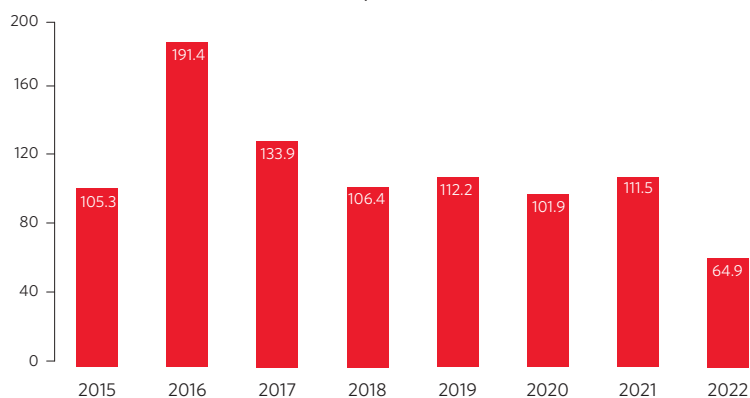


Efforts to reduce disaster impacts and risks have not yet stemmed billions in economic losses

Despite significant efforts to reduce disaster impacts, related economic losses remain stubbornly high. From 2015 to 2022, average annual direct economic losses exceeded \$115 billion worldwide, an amount equivalent to 0.3 per cent of the gross domestic product (GDP) of reporting countries.

LDCs and landlocked developing countries (LLDCs) suffer disproportionately from disasters. Disaster-related economic losses in LDCs are over six times the global average. From 2015 to 2022, this group of countries accounted for 6.9 per cent of global reported economic losses from disasters despite comprising only 1.1 per cent of reporting countries' combined GDP. Similarly, LLDCs reported 4.9 per cent of total economic losses, four times the global average, while accounting for only 1.1 per cent of reporting countries' combined GDP.

Direct economic losses from disasters, 2015-2022 (billions of dollars)

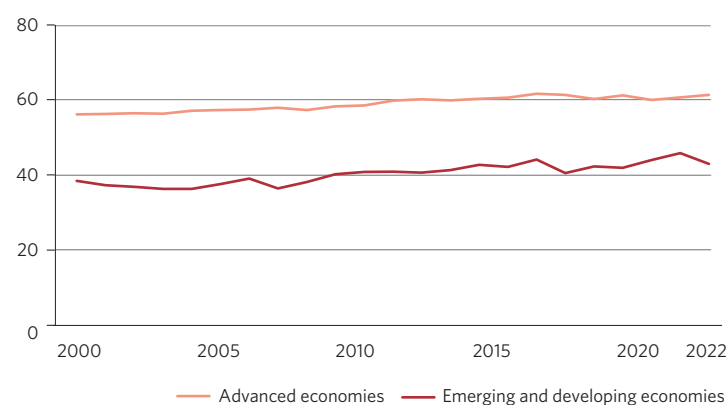


Government spending on essential services is ticking up but with a chronic gap between advanced and developing economies

Based on recent data from about 100 countries, worldwide government spending on essential services – encompassing education, health and social protection – averages around 50 per cent of total government expenditure. Among advanced economies, this figure rises to 60 per cent, while in emerging market and developing economies, it stands at 40 per cent. Over the past two decades, both groups have seen a slight uptick in their shares, maintaining a consistent 20-percentage-point gap between them.

On the components of essential services, advanced economies notably outpace emerging market and developing economies in social protection spending by roughly 15 percentage points on average, largely due to broader pension coverage. Health spending accounts for about 5 percentage points of this difference. The pandemic temporarily skewed these trends, with increased spending on social protection and health and a decline in education expenditure due to school closures. While these measures are expected to be short-lived, prolonged health issues and educational losses among individuals could potentially have long-term impacts on human capital.

Proportion of total government spending on essential services, 2000-2022 (percentage)





Zero hunger

- After rising sharply in the wake of the COVID-19 pandemic, global hunger and food insecurity remained persistently high and almost unchanged for three years. In 2023, about 733 million people faced hunger, and 2.33 billion people experienced moderate to severe food insecurity. Despite progress, 148 million children under age 5 suffered from stunting in 2022. If current trends persist, one in five children under age 5 will be affected by stunting in 2030.
- In 2022, almost 60 per cent of countries worldwide faced moderately to abnormally high food prices due to the spillover effects of conflicts, such as disrupted supply chains.
- Achieving zero hunger requires intensified efforts to transform food systems so they are sustainable, resilient and equitable. Moreover, accelerating improvements in diets, nutrition, health and hygiene is



A woman sells produce in a village on the southernmost tip of Madagascar, where farmers are struggling to harvest parched crops.

crucial to meeting the target of halving the number of children suffering from chronic undernutrition.

Hunger, food insecurity and malnutrition remain prevalent, calling for intensified efforts

After rising sharply from 2019 to 2021, global hunger, measured by the prevalence of undernourishment, persisted at nearly the same level for three years, affecting 9.1 per cent of the population in 2023 compared with 7.5 per cent in 2019. Between 713 and 757 million people faced hunger in 2023 – one in 11 people globally, and one in five in Africa. Moreover, an estimated 28.9 per cent of the world's population, or 2.33 billion people, were moderately or severely food insecure in 2023 – 383 million more than in 2019.

Malnutrition among children under age 5 remains a significant concern, posing heightened risks to their growth and development. Globally in 2022, an estimated 22.3 per cent of children under age 5, or 148 million, were affected by stunting (being too short for their age), down from 24.6 per cent in 2015. Based on current trends, one out of five (19.5 per cent) of children

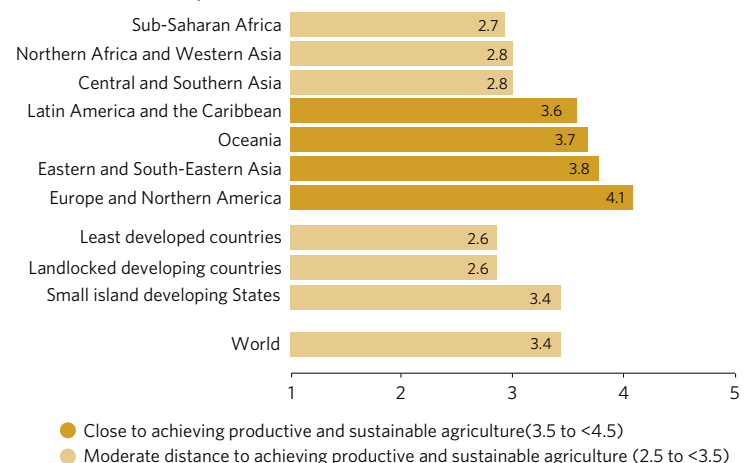
under age 5 will be affected by stunting in 2030. Some 37 million children (5.6 per cent) were overweight, while 45 million (6.8 per cent) experienced wasting, above the global target of 3 per cent by 2030. Three quarters of children under age 5 with stunting lived in Central and Southern Asia (36.7 per cent) and sub-Saharan Africa (38.3 per cent). More than half of those affected by wasting lived in Central and Southern Asia (56.2 per cent) and almost one quarter in sub-Saharan Africa (22.9 per cent).

To achieve Goal 2, significant efforts are needed to mitigate the impacts of climate change, conflict and economic crisis. Record-high food prices in 2022 worsened purchasing power and access to food, negatively impacting food security and nutritional outcomes. Increased global public expenditure on agriculture was at least one positive trend.

Accelerated action could bring productive and sustainable agriculture within reach globally

Productive and sustainable agriculture is key to ensuring the attainment and continued satisfaction of human needs in present and future generations. To assess global progress in sustainable agriculture, the Inter-agency and Expert Group on SDG Indicators adopted a new set of seven subindicators covering economic, social and environmental dimensions. Data from 2021 suggested that the world was at a moderate distance from achieving productive and sustainable agriculture (with a score of 3.4 out of 5) and had witnessed a slight improvement since 2015. Regional disparities were evident, however, with the highest score of 4.1 in Europe and Northern America compared to the lowest score of 2.6 in the LDCs. While more detailed analysis is required to investigate the root causes of varying rates of progress, evidence suggests that all regions urgently need to take sustained, concerted actions to improve productive and sustainable agriculture by 2030. They otherwise risk missing the target by a wide margin.

Status in achieving productive and sustainable agriculture, 2021 (score between 1 and 5)



Note: The score is derived using measures across economic, social and environmental dimensions. Scores are ranked based on five categories defined by the following criteria: productive and sustainable agriculture already achieved (4.5 to 5.5), close to achieving productive and sustainable agriculture (3.5 to <4.5), at a moderate distance to achieving productive and sustainable agriculture (2.5 to <3.5), far from achieving productive and sustainable agriculture (1.5 to <2.5), and very far from achieving productive and sustainable agriculture (1 to <1.5).

Small-scale food producers are vital in fighting hunger but earn less than half the income of larger-scale operations

Small-scale food producers play essential roles in agricultural and food production systems, enhancing resilience and fighting hunger. Despite their significant contributions, however, they are often among the most vulnerable groups in rural areas and within the broader agrifood system. In 95 per cent of countries with available data, the average annual income of small-scale producers is less than half that of larger-scale producers.

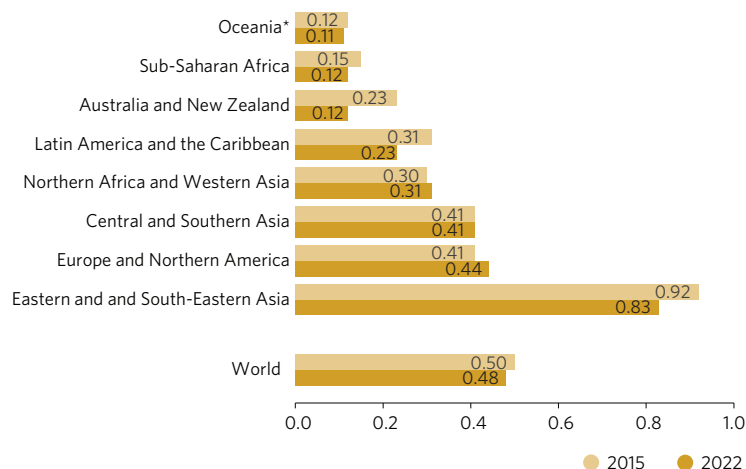
This income disparity persists across countries, regardless of income level. Small-scale food producers headed by men typically generate higher incomes than those headed by women. The latter had incomes that were less than 70 per cent of those earned by the former in nearly 50 per cent of countries with available data.

Global government spending and aid for agriculture surge amid economic challenges

Government spending reflects national priorities and can directly respond to economic and social challenges such as the COVID-19 pandemic, natural disasters or inflation. Between 2015 and 2022, global government spending on agriculture increased steadily, reaching a record high of \$749 billion in 2022. Government expenditure on agriculture relative to the sector's GDP contribution, as measured by the agriculture orientation index, declined from 0.5 in 2015 to 0.43 in 2021 before rebounding to 0.48 in 2022. The pandemic contributed to the fall as government resources were allocated to other sectors.

From 2015 to 2022, the volume of aid for agriculture provided to developing countries increased by 47.2 per cent, from \$12.3 billion to \$18.1 billion (in constant 2022 prices). A 33 per cent increase from 2021 to 2022 was primarily driven by agricultural development projects and initiatives in agricultural policy, administrative management and financial services. Notably, Africa accounted for 65 per cent of the increase in 2022, mainly due to non-concessional loans for agricultural development projects from the Islamic Development Bank in Egypt.

Agriculture orientation index, 2015 and 2022



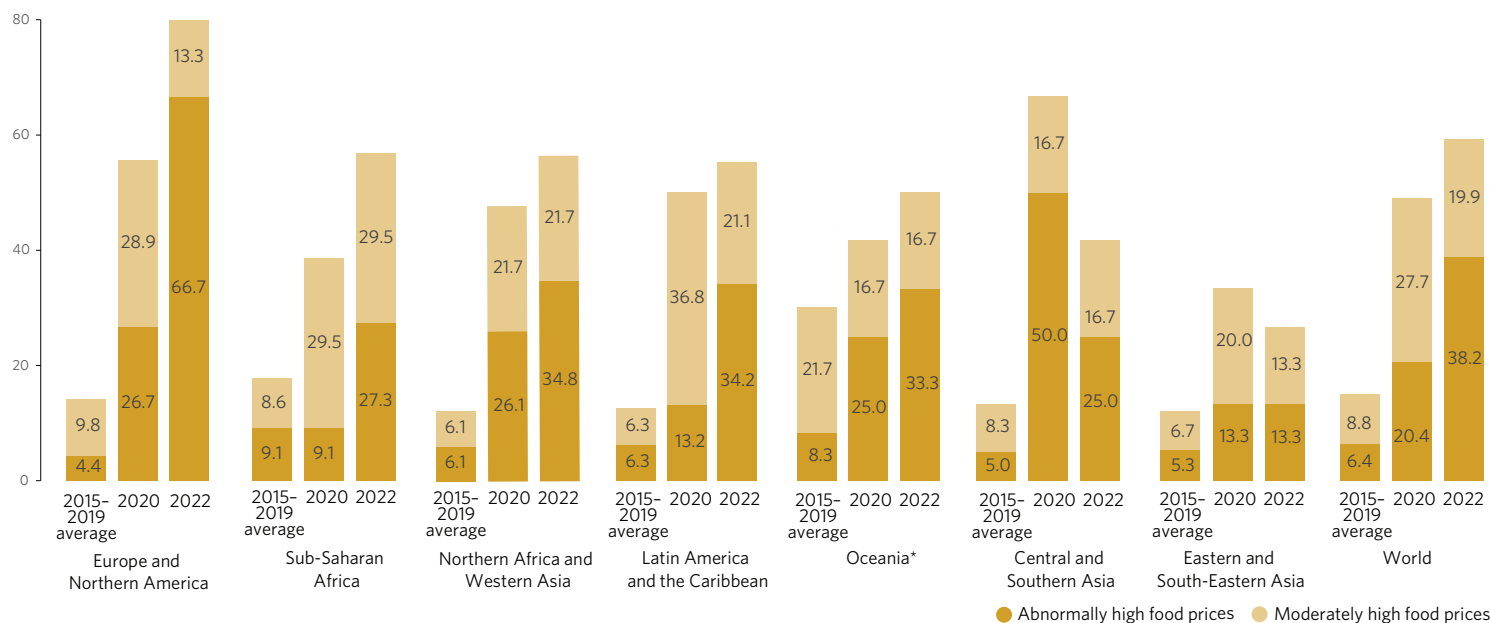
* Excluding Australia and New Zealand.

Nearly 60 per cent of countries faced moderately to abnormally high food prices in 2022

Globally, the proportion of countries facing moderately to abnormally high food prices rose sharply in 2022, reaching a new record high of 58.1 per cent. This represented a nearly fourfold increase from the 2015–2019 average level of 15.2 per cent. In Central and Southern Asia and Eastern and South-Eastern Asia, the share of countries facing moderately to abnormally high food prices in 2022 was lower than the peak in 2020 but

remained higher than the yearly average and the 2015–2019 average. The share steadily increased in sub-Saharan Africa between 2020 and 2022. Major disruptions to logistics and food supply chains after war broke out in Ukraine resulted in higher food and energy prices, particularly during the first half of 2022. The war also exerted strong upward pressure on fertilizer prices, adding uncertainty to farmer planting decisions.

Proportion of countries by region affected by moderately to abnormally high food prices, 2015–2019 average, 2020 and 2022 (percentage)



* Excluding Australia and New Zealand.



Good health and well-being

- The COVID-19 pandemic has ravaged global health, undoing nearly 10 years of progress in life expectancy. While most health-related indicators are moving in the right direction globally, current trends are insufficient to meet targets set for 2030.
- The maternal mortality ratio is largely stuck at a level more than three times the 2030 target. Under-5 deaths reached an historic low in 2022, but progress has slowed. Without accelerated declines, 35 million children will not live to see their fifth birthday by 2030.
- The global response to infectious diseases has saved millions of lives and paved the way for healthier communities. Inequalities and emerging threats jeopardize these accomplishments, however, underscoring the need for sustained efforts and innovative strategies.
- More than half the world's population is not covered by essential health services, while an ageing health workforce must now meet growing demands from an ageing population. Ensuring universal health coverage without financial hardship is crucial to healthy lives and well-being for all.



A child receives an oral polio vaccine during the launch of a nationwide polio campaign in Malawi.

- The world is not on track to achieve Goal 3. Changing course requires prioritizing the achievement of universal health coverage, strengthening health systems, investing in disease prevention and treatment, and addressing disparities in access to care and services, especially for vulnerable populations.

The COVID-19 pandemic turned back progress in life expectancy and gains in combating communicable diseases

The COVID-19 pandemic has significantly affected global health, reversing steady progress in life expectancy over the past two decades. Prior to the pandemic, global life expectancy rose consistently, from 66.8 years in 2000 to 73.1 years in 2019, reflecting years of improvements in health and related areas. COVID-19 swiftly reversed this positive trend, with global life expectancy plummeting to 71.4 years by 2021, back to the level of 2012.

Before the pandemic, non-communicable diseases had been steadily increasing as the leading cause of death, accounting for 59.5 per cent of all deaths in 2000 and 73.9 per cent in 2019. The share of communicable diseases dropped from 32.2 per cent in 2000 to 18.2 per cent in 2019. As COVID-19 emerged as a new infectious disease and started to take a toll on human lives, the share of deaths due to communicable diseases jumped back to the 2005 level (28.1 per cent) in 2021, while the share of deaths due to non-communicable diseases decreased to 65.3 per cent. COVID-19 ranked among the top three leading causes of death globally in 2020 and 2021, with striking regional variations.

Progress towards universal health coverage has slowed, leaving billions without care and subject to catastrophic costs

Essential health service coverage is measured using an index, reported on a score of 0 to 100, based on 14 indicators across four domains: reproductive, maternal, newborn and child health; infectious diseases; non-communicable diseases; and service capacity and access. The global score on the index increased remarkably from 45 in 2000 to 65 in 2015. Progress slowed thereafter, however, reaching a score of only 68 in 2021. The proportion of the population lacking essential health services fell by approximately 15 per cent between 2000 and 2021. Yet minimal progress after 2015 left about 4.5 billion people without coverage in 2021, especially in rural and poorer populations.

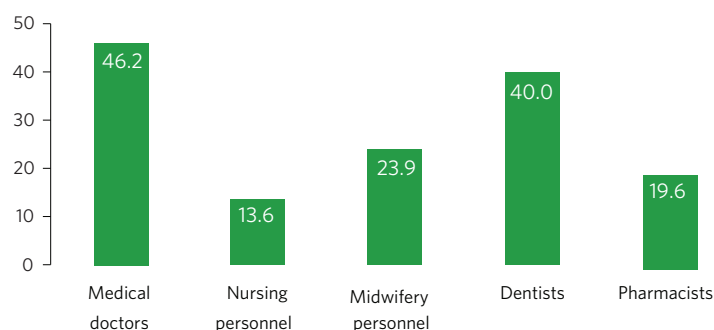
Financial hardship due to out-of-pocket health spending has worsened since 2015, affecting 2 billion people in 2019. They included 1 billion people facing catastrophic health expenditures exceeding 10 per cent of their household budget and 344 million driven deeper into extreme poverty by health costs. The proportion of the population with catastrophic expenditures increased from 12.6 per cent in 2015 to 13.5 per cent in 2019.

An ageing health workforce struggles to meet rising demands from an ageing population

Progressing towards universal health coverage requires addressing the global shortage of health workers. Yet data from 2015 to 2022 reveal stark disparities, with low-income countries experiencing the lowest health worker density and distribution. Per 10,000 people, these countries had medians of only 1.1 medical doctors, 7.5 nursing and midwifery personnel, 0.04 dentists and 0.2 pharmacists, compared with medians in high-income countries of 35.6 medical doctors, 76.8 nursing and midwifery personnel, 7.0 dentists and 8.8 pharmacists.

Health systems are experiencing increased strains in catering to the mounting health needs of an ageing global population, more so because the health workforce itself is ageing. An estimated 1.8 million additional health workers are needed in 54 countries, primarily high-income ones, to replace retiring health professionals and maintain the current age-standardized density of health workers.

Share of countries with an ageing workforce, by health occupation, 2017–2022 (percentage)



Note: A health workforce is considered "ageing" when the share of health workers aged 55 years and above exceeds that of health workers aged 35 years and below.